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Why Night Owls Don't Respond to Antidepressants



The Social Jetlag–Brain Connection

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The Problem Isn't Sleep, It's Timing

Most workplaces follow a 9-to-5 schedule, but many people have a naturally late body clock (chronotype).

When night owls repeatedly wake before their brain is ready, they experience social jetlag, a mismatch between biological time and social time.

Over time, this constant circadian strain increases the risk of depression, anxiety, and emotional exhaustion.





What Happens Inside the Brain?

Chronic social jetlag disrupts the brain's internal clock, affecting stress hormones like cortisol.

Research suggests this may contribute to thinning of the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC), a brain region involved in:

- Emotion regulation
- Decision-making
- Stress control

These brain changes may make mood disorders more persistent.

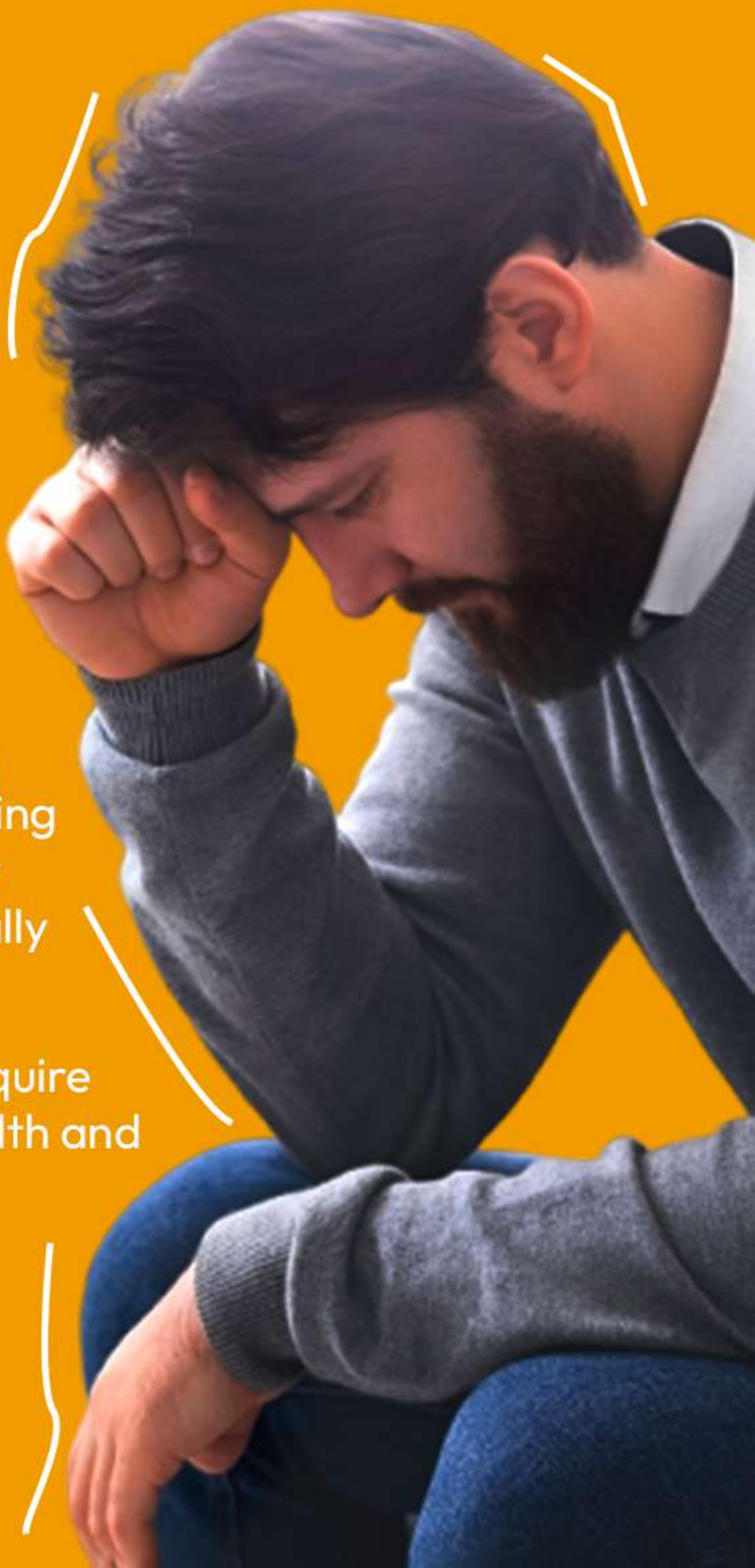
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Why Treatment May Be Less Effective

Studies show that people with a late chronotype are more likely to experience treatment-resistant depression.

Medication and therapy can help many people, but ongoing circadian misalignment may reduce recovery by continually placing stress on the brain.

Treating depression may require addressing both mental health and biological timing.



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Small Changes Can Make a Difference

Reducing social jetlag may improve mood and support recovery.

1. Maintain a consistent sleep schedule, even on weekends.

2. Get bright light at the appropriate time for your routine.

3. If possible, use flexible work or study hours that better match your chronotype.

4. Discuss sleep timing with a mental health professional when seeking treatment.



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